SOFT POWER METHOD

The Boundary Protocol

HOW TO SET A BOUNDARY, SURVIVE THE DISCOMFORT, AND HOLD IT

For the woman whose body says no,

but whose mouth still says yes.

BY MARIJA DJUROVIC
@MARIJASOFTPOWER

INTRODUCTION

Before You Begin

You do not struggle to set boundaries. You struggle to survive what happens in your body after you set one, the guilt, the scan for danger, the urge to explain, the impulse to go back and clean up the other person's discomfort.

This protocol is built for that exact sequence. It will teach you how to recognize when a boundary is needed, say it simply, survive the discomfort that follows, and hold it when someone pushes back.

Each section ends with a short exercise. Do it before moving on. Reading alone will not change the pattern. Repetition will.

There is also a final section for the moments when someone catches you off guard and your mind goes blank, phrases to use before your brain fully comes back online.

PART ONE

Spot It

How to recognize when a boundary is needed

Your body knows before your mind catches up. The stomach drops, the throat tightens, the chest closes, the shoulders rise, and before you have even processed what was asked of you, your mouth is already forming the word yes.

That yes is not a choice. It is a reflex.

Your nervous system learned a long time ago that no is costly. That it can escalate, threaten connection, pull approval away, or destabilize what feels like safety. So it found a shortcut: skip the decision, go straight to compliance, keep the peace.

And then the body reacts, not only to the request, but to the betrayal. Because somewhere underneath the automatic yes, you felt it. The drop. The tightening. The quiet knowing that this was not okay with you.

That feeling is not weakness. That feeling is your boundary trying to exist before you silence it.

You are not too agreeable, not too soft, not weak. You are very, very well trained.

BEFORE YOU MOVE ON — A SMALL EXERCISE

Next time someone asks something of you, pause before you answer. Just one breath. And notice: did your stomach drop, did your throat tighten, did your shoulders rise before your mind even processed the question? If yes, that is your body voting no before you had the chance to.

Then ask yourself:

- *Am I saying yes because I want to, or because I am afraid of what happens if I do not?*
- *What am I actually agreeing to, and for how long?*
- *If this person could not be disappointed, what would my answer be?*
- *What will this yes cost me by tomorrow?*

You do not have to answer out loud yet. Just start noticing. Noticing comes first.

When you are ready, move to Part Two.

PART TWO

Say It

How to actually say the boundary

Nobody taught you how to do this. That is not a character flaw, it is a gap in your education. You were taught to be kind, to be considerate, to think about how your words land on other people. And somewhere in that training, the assumption slipped in that a boundary needs to be justified in order to be valid.

It does not.

The moment you start explaining, you start negotiating. And the moment you start negotiating, you make it easier for the other person to talk you out of your own position. A boundary is not a debate opening. It is a statement. The simpler the words, the cleaner the delivery, not because simplicity sounds strong, but because simplicity leaves less room to negotiate.

WHEN YOU NEED SOMETHING TO STOP

> *"I need you to stop speaking to me in that tone."*

> *"I need you to stop doing that."*

WHEN YOU ARE SETTING A NEW STANDARD

> *"From now on, I expect you to be on time to every meeting."*

> *"From now on, this is how I need this to work."*

WHEN YOU ARE DEFINING YOUR SPACE

> *"I'm not comfortable with that around me."*

> *"That doesn't work for me."*

Short, clear, no maybe, no apology, no explanation. The subject is always you, not a moral judgment of them, just your position. You are not required to make your boundary comfortable for the person receiving it.

> BEFORE YOU MOVE ON — PRACTICE THIS
>
> Pick one low-stakes situation this week, not your hardest relationship, not your biggest fear. Something small. A request you want to decline, a favor that does not work for you, a plan you do not want to join. Say it in one sentence. No because, no apology, no explanation. Then stop talking.
>
> The silence after a simple boundary feels enormous at first. Let it be there. You do not have to fill it. If you catch yourself about to explain, pause, take one breath, and ask yourself: am I explaining because

> this person needs information, or because I cannot tolerate their discomfort?
>
> Practice on something small first. Tell the waiter the coffee is not what you ordered and ask for a new one. That is enough. That moment will tell you where the pattern lives.

Take your time with this. Part Three is waiting when you are.

PART THREE

Survive It

How to not collapse after the boundary

Your nervous system does not know the difference between disappointment and danger. So after the boundary is said cleanly and simply, the body braces, the mind starts scanning, the guilt arrives, the urge to go back appears. Not because you did something wrong, but because your system is trying to return to the only version of safety it has practiced the longest.

That safety was you adjusting, you absorbing, you making it easier for everyone else to stay comfortable.

Here is what many women do not expect: in most ordinary moments, the body is louder than the room. The war you prepared for often does not happen outside you. It happens inside your own system. And that matters, because it changes what the work actually is. The work is not only saying the boundary. The work is staying with yourself after you say it.

After you state it, stop. Completely. No follow-up text twenty minutes later, no softening message, no re-entering the conversation to check whether

the other person is okay, no trying to manage how they received it. The boundary has been stated. Your energy does not chase the outcome. The ball is in their court, you do not go pick it up for them.

The guilt will come. That is not evidence that you were wrong. That is your system meeting a version of you it has not learned to trust yet. Feel it, do not move from it, do not act on it. There is a difference between guilt and evidence.

> BEFORE YOU MOVE ON
>
> For the next 48 hours, after every boundary you set, written, spoken, small or large, do one thing. Put your phone down, close the laptop, leave the room. Not forever. Just long enough to interrupt the reflex of checking how they received it. You said what was true for you. That is where your responsibility ends.
>
> Then notice what happens in your body when you do not follow up. Write it down. That discomfort is not failure. That discomfort is the work.

Do the work here first. Then continue.

PART FOUR

Hold It

How to maintain the boundary when someone pushes back

When someone pushes back on a boundary, they are not necessarily being malicious. They are testing whether you meant it. And the only answer to that test is repetition, not louder, not with more explanation, but the same words, the same tone, the same stillness.

> *"That doesn't work for me."*

Again. Without elaboration, without anger, without emotional performance. Because the boundary was already stated, and nothing new has happened that requires a new speech.

If they continue, you introduce a consequence. Not as a threat. As information.

> *"If you continue to speak to me in that tone, I'm going to end this conversation."*

That is enough. You do not warn twice, you do not negotiate for five more rounds, you do not explain

the consequence into the ground. You say it once, clearly, and then you wait long enough to see whether they choose to respect it. And if they do not, you do what you said you would do. You end the conversation, you leave the room, you hang up, you stop engaging. Whatever you said, you do it.

This is the part most women skip. They state the consequence and then absorb the violation anyway, hoping the words alone will be enough. They will not be.

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE IN PRACTICE

> *"I need you to stop speaking to me in that tone."*
>
> *→ "I've already mentioned this. If it continues, I'm going to end this conversation."*
>
> *→ They continue. You end the conversation.*

> *"From now on, I expect you to be on time to every meeting."*
>
> *→ "This is the second time. If this keeps happening, I'll need to reconsider how we structure our time together."*
>
> *→ It happens again. You act on it.*

> *"I'm not comfortable with that around me."*
>
> *→ "I said this once already. If it happens again, I'm going to leave."*
>
> *→ It happens again. You leave.*

Every time you hold it, really hold it, and act on it, you teach people how you function. Not with a speech. With behavior. A boundary that collapses the moment someone pushes is not a boundary. It is an invitation to keep pushing.

> BEFORE YOU MOVE ON
>
> Think of one boundary you stated in the last month that you did not follow through on. Not to judge yourself. Just to see it clearly. What did you say you would do? What did you actually do? Write it down. Then write what you would do differently now, specifically, in one sentence. That sentence is your plan for next time. Keep it somewhere you can find it.
>
> Notice exactly where you broke. That is the only part you need to work on.

Write it down before you move on.

FINAL SECTION

When Your Mind Goes Blank

Emergency Phrases for the Freeze Response

This section exists because of a pattern I have seen in almost every woman I have worked with. And lived myself.

Someone catches you off guard, a comment that should not have been made, a tone that has no business being directed at you, a moment of unexpected cruelty from someone you did not clock as a threat. And your response is silence. Or defense. Neither feels good afterward.

The silence leaves you replaying the moment for hours, building the perfect response in your head later, frustrated with yourself for not saying anything. But you were not slow and you were not weak. You were unprepared for that exact kind of moment, and your nervous system had no language protocol ready.

The defense feels more active, but it often costs just as much. The moment you defend yourself on their terms, you step into their frame. And their frame was built for the fight. Yours was not.

Freeze is not a flaw. It is a body response without a language protocol. These phrases give you one.

What works in practice is not a clever comeback, not the perfect response, not winning the exchange. What works is a set of pre-learned phrases your mouth can produce before your brain has fully caught up. You learn them in advance, you keep them ready, and when the moment hits, you do not need to think. You use one.

YOUR FREEZE PHRASE SET

"I don't think I understood. Could you repeat that?"

"What is it that you're actually asking me?"

"I'm going to stop you there."

"I need a moment before I respond to this."

"I don't like you talking to me like that."

These are not full boundaries. They are bridges, from the moment of freeze to the moment your mind catches up and you can decide how to proceed. You do not need the perfect response. You need the first one.

LET THIS SIT

Do not rush to do this perfectly.

Use one sentence, hold one moment,

notice what happens next.

That is enough for now.

@marijasoftpower

thesoftpowermethod.com